

Amazon Account Health & Restricted Products

A working conversation on suspension triggers, restricted vs prohibited products, and listing-copy compliance

Full Circle Agency · Conversation transcript

This document captures a full working session covering the Account Health page and its suspension triggers, a deep dive into Restricted Products policy violations, the practical distinction between prohibited and gated products (illustrated with two real enforcement notices), how to determine a product's status before selling, a cross-category compliance brief for content writers, and how all of it connects to the listing-rewrite SOP.

FULL (You)

Let's talk about the account health page on Seller Central. What things and violations can get the account on Amazon suspended. I want to dig deep into everything.

CLAUDE

Good topic. This is the stuff that actually keeps clients up at night, so here is the whole landscape, how the page is structured, and where the real suspension triggers hide.

How the Account Health page is structured

The page hangs off one master number, the Account Health Rating (AHR), scored 0 to 1000. Green (200 and above) is healthy, yellow (100 to 199) is at risk, red (below 100) means Amazon can deactivate. The number moves based on unresolved policy violations weighted by severity, minus any credit for time passing without new issues. A single critical violation can drag you into the red instantly regardless of everything else being clean. The AHR is not an average, it is a penalty-driven score.

Underneath the AHR sit three performance buckets plus the policy compliance area.

1. Customer Service Performance

Only one metric here really matters for survival: Order Defect Rate (ODR), which must stay under 1%. ODR rolls up negative feedback (1 or 2 stars), A-to-z Guarantee claims, and service chargebacks. Blowing past 1% ODR is one of the classic account-level suspension paths, especially for FBM sellers. It is measured over a 60-day window, so a bad stretch lingers.

2. Shipping Performance (seller-fulfilled only)

FBA insulates you from most of this. For FBM: Late Shipment Rate under 4%, Pre-fulfillment Cancel Rate under 2.5%, Valid Tracking Rate over 95%. On-time Delivery is tracked but not a hard deactivation trigger on its own. Chronic breaches usually cost Prime badge or Buy Box before the account, but sustained failure feeds into deactivation.

3. Policy Compliance — where most suspensions originate

This is the section to obsess over. The severe items are account killers on their own:

- **Intellectual property:** suspected IP violations, received IP complaints (trademark, copyright, patent, design). Repeat IP infringement triggers enforcement fast.
- **Product authenticity:** counterfeit / inauthentic complaints. Arguably the single most dangerous category. One complaint or a failed test buy can suspend the ASIN or the whole account and demand supply-chain documentation.
- **Product condition:** used sold as new, common on commingled FBA inventory.
- **Product safety:** safety complaints, expired products, recalls, hazmat. Often bypasses the normal warning ladder.
- **Listing policy violations:** detail-page breaches, variation abuse, prohibited claims (drug/disease claims on supplements and cosmetics), image policy.
- **Restricted product policy violations:** selling into gated or prohibited categories, restricted ingredients, items requiring approval you do not have.
- **Customer product reviews violations:** review manipulation, incentivized reviews, review gating. Enforced hard as fraud-adjacent.
- **Code of Conduct violations:** the catch-all — multiple accounts, rank/search/rating manipulation, Buy Box or price manipulation, false information to Amazon, system abuse, fraud.

Categories that suspend without a warning ladder

Counterfeit / inauthenticity, safety complaints and recalls, IP infringement (especially repeat), Code of Conduct fraud items, and restricted-product breaches can jump straight to deactivation. The performance metrics (ODR, shipping) are the ones that usually give you runway.

Two suspension paths people conflate

Performance-based deactivation (driven by AHR / policy violations, appealed with a Plan of Action) versus verification-based / identity deactivations, where Amazon freezes you pending business verification, video call, utility bills, or bank matching. The second is documentary, not a POA. Clients panic and write a POA for a verification hold, which does nothing.

Levels of enforcement

In escalating order: listing deactivated, ASIN blocked, category/section review, full account deactivation, and at the far end permanent closure with funds held (up to 90 days) or forfeited for egregious fraud. Knowing which level you are at changes the response entirely.

Account Health Assurance

If eligible and enrolled, Amazon commits not to deactivate without first talking to you, provided you engage with their outreach. A meaningful safety net for established sellers with good history. Worth confirming which accounts have it.

What to monitor weekly per account

ODR trend against the 1% line, any new entry under Policy Compliance (treat a single authenticity or safety flag as a same-day fire), the AHR number and its direction, valid tracking and late shipment for FBM SKUs, and whether Account Health Assurance still shows active.

Accuracy note: enforcement mechanics and thresholds shift, and this knowledge runs to early 2026, so for any live suspension confirm the current appeal flow on the account before acting.

FULL (You)

Let's talk everything about restricted product policy violations in detail, each and every part.

CLAUDE

Restricted products is a deep and messy category because it blends two different things Amazon lumps under one heading, and confusing them is where sellers get burned.

The core distinction: restricted vs prohibited

Restricted (gated) means the product can be sold, but only with approval, documentation, certification, or category ungating. Selling it without clearing that gate is the violation.

Prohibited means it cannot be sold on Amazon at all, by anyone, ever. Listing one is an instant violation with no path to approval, only removal and enforcement.

Many restricted-product flags are actually about the second bucket, and sellers waste time trying to get approved for something that has no approval path.

The full landscape of restricted product categories

Amazon maintains a long list, each with its own sub-page and rules. The major ones: alcohol; animals and animal products (ivory, CITES, furs); fine art and collectibles; automotive and powersports (CARB, EPA, defeat devices); composite wood (CARB/TSCA formaldehyde); cosmetics and skincare; dietary supplements; drugs and drug paraphernalia; electronics (FCC, jammers, radar detectors); explosives and weapons; export controls; food and beverage; gambling and lottery; hazmat; human parts and burial artifacts; jewelry and precious gems; laser products; lighting; lock picking and theft devices; medical devices and accessories; offensive and controversial materials; pesticides and pesticide devices; plant and seed products; postage and stamps; recalled products; recycling electronics; subscriptions and periodicals; surveillance equipment; tobacco and vaping; warranties and service plans; and used products in certain categories.

The ones most relevant to this portfolio: cosmetics/skincare, dietary supplements, drugs, medical devices, and pesticides.

How a restricted product violation actually gets triggered

- Automated keyword and claim scanning of titles, bullets, descriptions, A+ content, and image text.
- Category miscategorization via the wrong browse node.
- Ingredient or component detection for supplements, cosmetics, and food.

- Test buys and safety complaints.
- Missing required documentation for a gated category.
- Regulatory feeds — Amazon ingests CPSC/FDA recall data and pulls recalled ASINs automatically.
- Compliance requests you fail to answer in time or answer inadequately.

The pesticide and drug-claim trap in detail

Unapproved drug reclassification. The moment a supplement or cosmetic claims to diagnose, cure, mitigate, treat, or prevent a disease, it is treated as an unapproved new drug. Acne, eczema, and inflammation claims cross the line; structure/function claims (supports healthy joints) are allowed with the disclaimer. Often a copy problem, but Amazon may suspend first.

Pesticide reclassification. Any product claiming to kill, repel, or mitigate pests or microorganisms can be deemed a pesticide requiring EPA registration — antimicrobial cases, antibacterial fabrics, mold-resistant products, repellents, broad-kill sanitizers. Enforcement is aggressive and appeals are documentation-heavy.

Hazmat and dangerous goods interaction with FBA

Products with lithium batteries, aerosols, flammables, corrosives, or pressurized contents need an SDS or exemption sheet before FBA accepts them. Failure means stranded, blocked, or destroyed inventory, and repeated hazmat errors show up as compliance issues. Hits aerosol sprays, alcohol-based products, and some cosmetics.

Enforcement severity and the missing warning ladder

These skew harsh and often skip the warning courtesy: listing removed, then ASIN block requiring documentation, then a category or account hold, then full deactivation. Safety and prohibited-item violations most often jump straight to deactivation with funds held. The pattern that kills accounts is repeat violations in the same category, which Amazon reads as willful or systemic.

Appealing a restricted product violation

Documentary and root-cause driven, not an emotional POA. Identify the exact policy and ASIN. Determine whether it is a content problem (a claim, fixed by editing) or a product problem (banned ingredient or uncertified item, needing removal or proof). Assemble the documentation Amazon accepts for that category (ingredient lists, drug facts panel, FDA/EPA registration, CPC/GCC, lab reports, CARB/TSCA certs). Write a root cause + corrective + preventive structure. Keep it factual and evidence-led.

Prevention — where an agency earns its keep

- A pre-listing compliance gate running copy against a banned-claims list segmented by category.
- A per-SKU documentation vault (ingredient lists, SDS, certs, registrations, lab reports) kept before you need them.
- A category gating audit confirming approvals are current.

- Claim discipline in A+ and images, not just text.
- A recall monitoring habit against CPSC/FDA feeds.
- An ingredient watchlist (DMAA, DMHA, ephedra, certain sarms, prohibited color additives) screened against supplement/cosmetic clients.

Accuracy caveat: Amazon revises category rules and required documents regularly; for any live enforcement, confirm the specific policy page and current accepted-document list on the account.

FULL (You)

[Shared two real enforcement screenshots.] You explained 2 types of products, prohibited and gated. Under what category does this violation come, or is there another?

Screenshot 1 — UK: A high-power FPV/RPV video transmitter (ASIN B0H7JT6171), flagged under Restricted Products Policy Violations, listing removed, No impact on AHR. Notice states it cannot be legally used in the UK and is therefore prohibited on Amazon.co.uk, citing Ofcom.

Screenshot 2 — US: A Portable Pet Nebulizer (ASIN B0H5FP3C8S), flagged under Restricted Products Policy Violation, listing removed, Medium AHR impact. Notice states the nebulizer is a medical device requiring FDA clearance and either an Amazon Business account + Professional Healthcare Program membership, or a documented 510(k) package.

CLAUDE

Both still live under the same umbrella heading, Restricted Products Policy Violation. That heading is the bucket Amazon files everything in. But the two-way split still holds underneath, and these two images are a clean illustration of each side.

The pet nebulizer is the gated/restricted type.

The giveaway is that Amazon hands you a path to sell it: hold an Amazon Business account and be an authorized member of the Professional Healthcare Program, or if it has FDA clearance for OTC use, provide packaging photos, instructions, and the 510(k) number. The product is not banned; it sits behind a gate, and the violation is that it went live without clearing the gate. Nuance: this is a program gate plus a documentation route, a stricter flavor than ordinary category ungating.

The FPV/RPV transmitter is the prohibited type.

The language is the tell: it cannot be legally used in the UK and is therefore prohibited. No program, no documentation route, no approval path. Nuance: this is a marketplace-specific prohibition driven by local regulation (UK radio spectrum rules, hence Ofcom), not a universal one. The same physical product might be sellable on another marketplace where the RF regulation differs. Prohibited does not always mean prohibited everywhere.

So: no third fundamental category. Everything routes through the restricted-products heading, and every case underneath is either prohibited (no path) or gated (has a path).

Two practical things the screenshots reveal

- **AHR impact differs and should drive triage.** The FPV notice says No impact; the nebulizer says Medium. Even though both show Submit appeal, the nebulizer is the one pulling the score down and

deserves priority.

- **The appeal means something different in each case.** For the nebulizer (gated), the appeal is a real route to selling: enroll in the program, or submit the 510(k) package. For the FPV (prohibited), there is no approval; the only sane angle is to contest the identification itself (argue it is within permitted power limits or compliant) backed by RF specs or a declaration of conformity. If it genuinely is a high-power unit, there is no winning appeal — leave it removed and never re-list, because re-listing a prohibited item is the repeat pattern that escalates to account level.

FULL (You)

But how do I know if the product I am going to start selling on the platform is itself prohibited or gated?

CLAUDE

There is no single lookup, which is exactly why sellers get caught. But there is a reliable order of operations. Prohibited vs gated is not always a property of the product itself — it depends on the marketplace, the category, and often the specific claims you make. So you check it in layers, cheapest and fastest first.

- **Layer 1 — Try to list it and read what Amazon tells you.** Free and underrated. The add-a-product flow will let you list (not gated for you), show Apply to sell / Request approval (gated, and it names what it wants), or block it outright (prohibited or hard-gated). Do this before buying inventory.
- **Layer 2 — Check the Restricted Products help pages for the category.** Each has its own sub-page distinguishing outright-prohibited from allowed-with-conditions. Bookmark supplements, cosmetics/skincare, drugs, medical devices, and pesticides.
- **Layer 3 — Check category approval / gating status.** Some items are gated as categories or brands even when not on the restricted list. Gating is account-specific, so a product ungated for one seller may be gated for another.
- **Layer 4 — Screen your own claims and ingredients.** The layer people skip and the one that silently flips a legal product into a prohibited one. A cream becomes an unapproved drug the moment copy says treats eczema; a cleaner becomes an unregistered pesticide when it says kills 99.9% of germs. Screen title, bullets, A+, and images against banned claims, and screen ingredients against prohibited lists.
- **Layer 5 — Check the underlying regulator.** Amazon mirrors FDA, EPA, CPSC, Ofcom, CARB, FCC, but its help pages lag. If the product touches health, safety, pests, radio frequency, batteries, children, or emissions, check the regulator directly. The FPV case is a pure regulatory one.
- **Layer 6 — Confirm per marketplace.** Prohibition can be country-specific. Verify each marketplace separately; US-clear does not mean UK-clear.

Summary: gated products announce themselves through the Apply to sell button and the help pages; prohibited products announce themselves by giving no path and citing a regulation. The dangerous middle is products that look clear until a claim or ingredient reclassifies them, and the only defense there is disciplined pre-listing screening.

FULL (You)

I think we can avoid Layer 4 if we have a content writer and we give him detailed instructions to avoid these things. What should that be — detailed instructions that apply to all categories and products?

CLAUDE

Careful with the framing. A content writer with good instructions reduces the claims risk a lot, but it does not let you delete Layer 4 entirely. Layer 4 is also about ingredients and product function, not just words (the nebulizer had no bad claims and still got hit, because the object itself is a medical device), and a writer following a wordlist still misses category-specific gray zones. So treat this as the writer's guardrail so claims almost never trigger a flag, while ingredient and device screening stays with compliance.

The instruction set was delivered as a reusable Word document. Its structure:

The one idea behind all of it

Amazon reacts to what your words claim, not what the product does. The moment copy says a product treats, cures, prevents, kills, heals, or diagnoses anything, an ordinary product can be reclassified into a regulated one. Every rule is a version of that.

Rule 1 — Never claim to treat, cure, prevent, or diagnose anything

Banned verbs in any form: treat, cure, heal, prevent, diagnose, remedy, fix, reverse, restore, correct, eliminate a condition, fight or combat a disease. Sample rewrites:

Do not write	Write instead
Treats acne and clears breakouts	Helps you maintain the look of clear, healthy skin
Relieves joint pain and arthritis	Supports joint comfort and mobility
Prevents colds and boosts immunity to fight illness	Supports a healthy immune system
Reverses signs of aging and sun damage	Helps reduce the appearance of fine lines

Rule 2 — Use structure/function language, and know the difference

The legal safe lane: supports, promotes, maintains, aids, nourishes, plus a normal body function. Supports healthy digestion is fine; relieves IBS is a drug claim. For supplements, pair with the FDA disclaimer.

Rule 3 — Never claim to kill, repel, or eliminate germs, bacteria, viruses, mold, or pests

The pesticide trap. Banned: kills 99.9% of germs, antibacterial, antimicrobial, disinfects, sanitizes, mold-resistant, repels insects. Sample rewrites:

Do not write	Write instead
Antibacterial phone case kills 99.9% of germs	Easy-to-wipe-clean surface for everyday use
Kills mold and mildew on contact	Helps clean surfaces and remove visible residue

Natural mosquito repellent keeps bugs away	Fresh botanical scent for indoor and outdoor spaces
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Exception: if the client holds an EPA registration or the product is a registered disinfectant, some claims are allowed and must be worded a specific way. Escalate to confirm before writing.

Rule 4 — Do not describe a product as a medical device or give it a medical function

Handle with care: nebulizer, inhaler, therapeutic, medical grade, FDA approved (never write unless documented), diagnostic, treats respiratory conditions, drug delivery. If a product truly is a device, flag it — do not word around it.

Rules 5–7 — Superlatives, social proof, and safety claims

- No unverifiable superlatives (best, #1, guaranteed, 100% effective, proven) and no promotional or pricing/shipping language on the detail page. No URLs, emails, or phone numbers.
- No reviews, ratings, testimonials, or manufactured social proof in the copy.
- Do not invent certifications (BPA-free, non-toxic, hypoallergenic, food-safe, lead-free) without documentation, and never claim a product is safe or side-effect free.

Category quick-reference

- **Supplements:** highest disease-claim risk; structure/function only; confirm the FDA disclaimer.
- **Skincare/cosmetics:** may only cleanse, beautify, change appearance; appearance language for anti-aging, not repair or reverse.
- **Cleaning/home/consumer goods:** the pesticide trap lives here; no kill/sanitize/repel without EPA proof.
- **Health/wellness devices:** watch accidental medical-device framing; describe comfort and everyday use.
- **Food and beverage:** no disease or weight-loss cure claims; no unverified dietary claims.
- **Pet products:** same rules as for humans; animal use does not exempt a health or device claim (per the nebulizer case).

Pre-publish self-check and escalation

A seven-step search-your-text routine (disease verbs; kill/germ words; medical/device words; superlatives and certifications; price/shipping/reviews/URLs; A+ and image text; flag anything borderline). Plus explicit escalation triggers: a product that only makes sense with a health/medical claim, a product that is or contains a device/drug/regulated ingredient, a client insisting on a flagged claim, or a new un-briefed category.

Bottom line delivered in the doc: describe what the product is and the everyday benefit it gives, never a medical, germ-killing, or unprovable promise. When a product needs one of those claims to sell, that is a signal for compliance, not a challenge for copy.

FULL (You)

[Shared the Usman Handoff Listing Rewrite SOP.] Is this doc relevant to what we are doing? Explain in 5 lines what is discussed in this SOP.

CLAUDE

Yes, it is directly relevant — the operational companion to the compliance brief.

In brief: the SOP is a streamlined process for rewriting Amazon listings at volume (~900 families) using Claude Cowork plus Claude in Chrome, reading each listing and its reviews live off the Amazon page. It deliberately drops DataDive and VOC.AI (the round-one failure points that caused 403s and hangs) and mines Voice-of-Customer straight from the visible reviews, optimizing for conversion and accuracy rather than a keyword score. It works one parent variation family at a time, stopping every 3 for review, with a Master Prompt that writes 75-char titles, 5 bullets, a description, and backend search terms into a tracker sheet. Its non-negotiable Step 5 accuracy checklist enforces the same claim-discipline discussed here: never overclaim (no waterproof for water-resistant, no blackout for light-filtering), cut any claim you must mentally reframe to justify, and let reviews override marketing.

The connection: the SOP's accuracy checklist already bakes in claim honesty, so the content-writer compliance brief slots in as the restricted-products layer the SOP does not explicitly cover — disease, pesticide, and medical-device claims.

End of transcript. Companion deliverable: listing-compliance-instructions.docx (the cross-category content-writer compliance brief referenced in Turn 5).